

THE SERPENT

Serpens



SIZE RANKING 23

BRIGHTEST STAR
Unukalhai (α) 2.6GENITIVE
Serpentis

ABBREVIATION Ser

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
June–AugustFULLY VISIBLE
74°N–64°S

Although counted as a single constellation, Serpens is in fact split into two separate areas, and is thus unique. It is one of the original 48 Greek constellations and straddles the celestial equator. Serpens represents a huge snake coiled around Ophiuchus, who holds the head (Serpens Caput) in his left hand and the tail (Serpens Cauda) in his right. In Greek mythology, snakes were a symbol of rebirth, because of the fact that they shed their skins. Ophiuchus represents the great healer Asclepius, who was reputedly able to revive the dead (see panel, opposite).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The Eagle Nebula (see pp.244–245) in Serpens Cauda was made world-famous by a spectacular Hubble Space Telescope picture of dark columns of dust embedded within its glowing gas. Unfortunately, the dust columns show up only through a telescope of large aperture and on long-exposure photographs such as those from the Hubble Space Telescope.

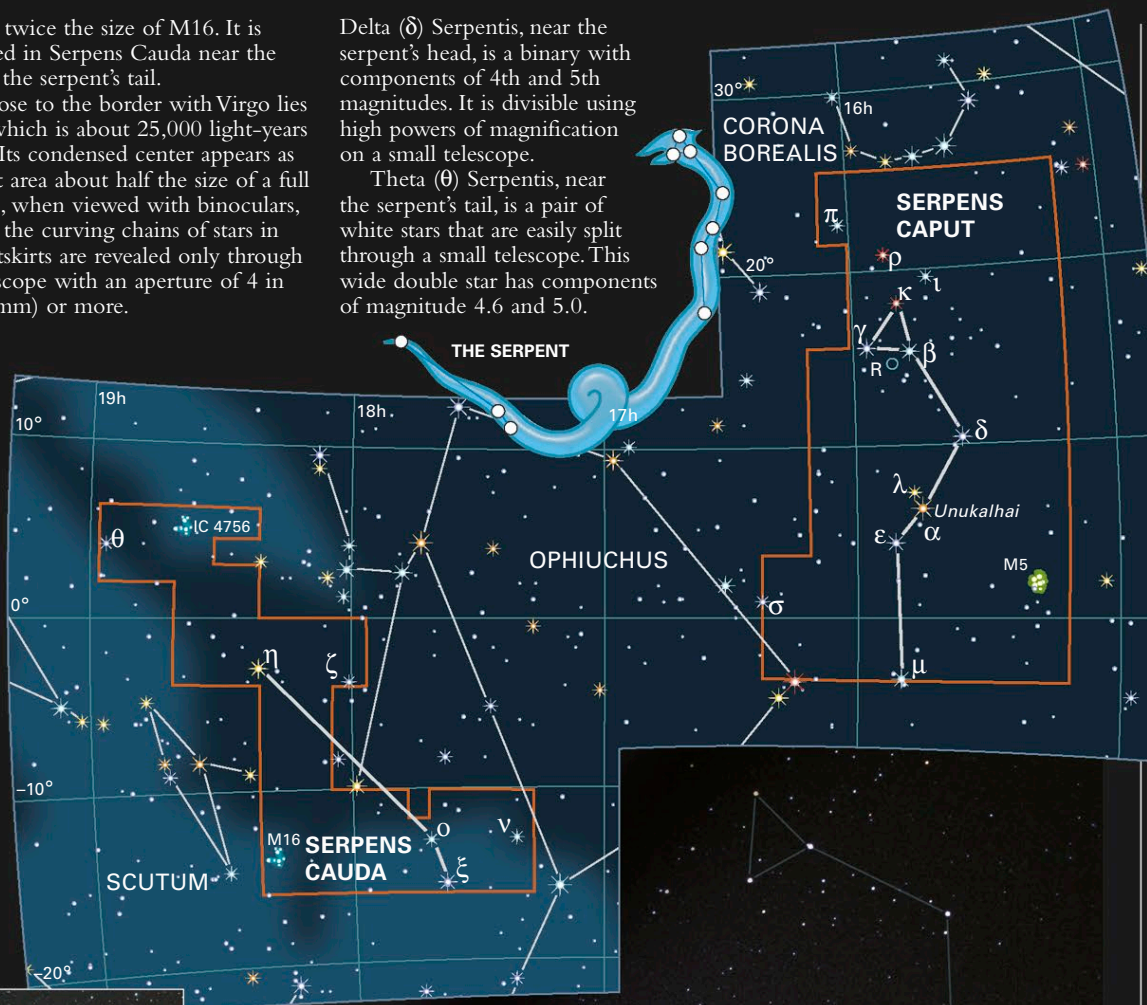
The Eagle Nebula contains a star cluster, M16, which can be spotted readily through binoculars or a small telescope. It appears as a hazy patch covering an area of sky that is similar in size to a full moon. Another open cluster that is visible through binoculars is IC 4756, which appears

about twice the size of M16. It is situated in Serpens Cauda near the tip of the serpent's tail.

Close to the border with Virgo lies M5, which is about 25,000 light-years away. Its condensed center appears as a faint area about half the size of a full moon, when viewed with binoculars, while the curving chains of stars in its outskirts are revealed only through a telescope with an aperture of 4 in (100 mm) or more.

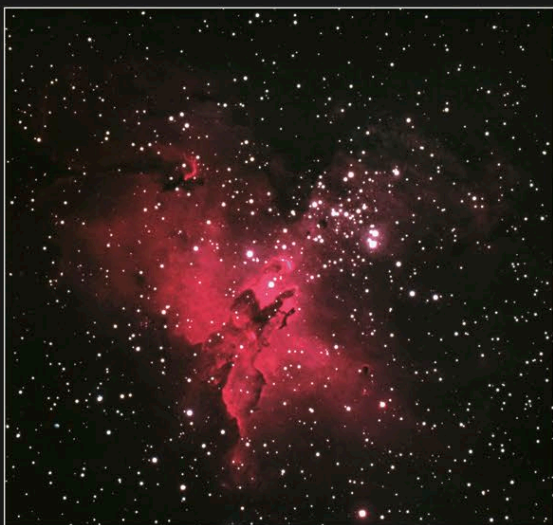
Delta (δ) Serpentis, near the serpent's head, is a binary with components of 4th and 5th magnitudes. It is divisible using high powers of magnification on a small telescope.

Theta (θ) Serpentis, near the serpent's tail, is a pair of white stars that are easily split through a small telescope. This wide double star has components of magnitude 4.6 and 5.0.



M5

This is one of the finest globular clusters in northern skies. M5 is noticeably elliptical in shape when viewed through a telescope.



THE EAGLE NEBULA

This image was captured by a professional 13-ft 1-in (4-m) telescope. It can only be seen well with telescopes of large aperture.

SERPENTINE STARS

The upper part of the snake (above, right) contains Unukalhai (α), which derives its name from the Arabic for "the serpent's neck."